

AMERICAN CIVIL WAR UNIFORMS

In the American Civil War of 1861–65, soldiers of the northern Union were well kitted out. From 1861, they were issued with standard issue uniforms and equipment mass-produced in factories in the north, on the orders of the War Department. By contrast, the soldiers of the southern Confederate States were often ill-equipped, and had to overcome a shortage of cartridges, uniform, tents, blankets, pay, and food. Sometimes they even had to march barefoot or rely on supplies of boots “liberated” from the Union forces.



◀ UNION SOLDIER'S FORAGE CAP

Date 1861

Origin US

Material Wool

Soldiers in the Union forces attached a regimental corps badge and brass numbers to the top of their forage cap. In this case, the “1” signifies “First Corps” and the “124” the New York 124th regiment.



Four brass buttons on the front

Domet (cotton warp and wool weft) flannel ensured warmth

◀ UNION SOLDIER'S UNIFORM

Date 1861

Origin US

Material Wool

Union soldiers wore a dark blue fatigue jacket and standard issue light blue trousers. Union forces kit was produced in a range of standard sizes to facilitate mass production.



Trousers were usually worn rolled up or tucked into socks when on campaign



▶ UNION OFFICER'S COCKED HAT

Date 1861

Origin US

Material Wool

Officers were entitled to wear this bicorne or “cocked hat” with a black rosette, ostrich plumes, and, attached to the side, a gilt Union eagle.



▶ UNION OFFICER'S DRESS JACKET

Date 1861

Origin US

Material Wool

Rather than wearing standard issue, officers bought their own uniform. The influence of the French army is evident in this dress jacket with upright collar, sleeve braid, and brass buttons.



Sleeve braid indicated rank